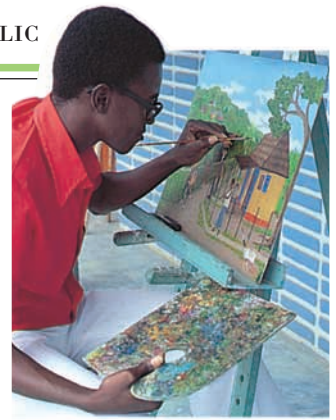


**HAITI****Capital city:** Port-au-Prince**Area:** 10,714 sq miles
(27,750 sq km)**Population:** 8,300,000**Official languages:**
French, French Creole**Major religions:** Christian
96%, other 4%**Government:** Multiparty
democracy**Currency:** Gourde**Adult literacy rate:** 52%**Life expectancy:** 54 years**People per doctor:** 5,000**Televisions:** 5 per 1,000
people**DOMINICAN
REPUBLIC****Capital city:** Santo
Domingo**Area:** 18,815 sq miles
(48,730 sq km)**Population:** 8,700,000**Official language:**
Spanish**Major religions:** Christian
92%, other 8%**Government:** Multiparty
democracy**Currency:** Dominican
Republic peso**Adult literacy rate:** 84%**Life expectancy:** 67 years**People per doctor:** 455**Televisions:** 95 per 1,000
people

HAITI

THE POOREST COUNTRY in the western world, Haiti shares the island of Hispaniola with the Dominican Republic. A revolution by African slaves in 1791, led by Toussaint L'Ouverture, broke French rule, and Haiti became the first black republic. Recent politics have been turbulent. The long dictatorship of the Duvalier family ("Papa" and "Baby Doc"), gave way to a series of military coups. Political unrest continues and the country suffers from great poverty. Many Haitians practice the religious cult of voodoo, which blends traditional African beliefs with Roman Catholicism. Followers believe in powerful spirits, and dancing to the beat of sacred drums is part of the voodoo ritual.

**ART AND CULTURE**

Many Haitians try to make extra money by selling craft goods, such as straw hats and woodcarvings, and by acting as unofficial tourist guides. Since the 1930s, artists have been noted for producing simple, bold paintings in a style derived from the decorations in voodoo temples.

**SOIL EROSION**

Farming is the main occupation here and most Haitians live on small plots of land, growing food and keeping goats. They make very little money and pressure for more land to farm means that trees are constantly being cut down. Some wood is turned into charcoal, shown here, and used as fuel in rural areas. Goats overgraze on the remaining woodland. The exposed soil has now become so severely eroded that crop yields are poor. It has been estimated that one-third of the land in Haiti is no longer arable.

DOMINICAN REPUBLIC

THE LANDSCAPE OF MOUNTAINS and forests in the Dominican Republic may be similar to that of its island neighbor, but other aspects of life are very different. Spain was the main colonial power here and US influences are also strong. The people and the culture are a mix of Spanish, African, and native peoples. The country is rich in natural resources, with deposits of silver, platinum, uranium, and nickel, and one of the world's largest gold mines. However, tourism is by far the most important source of foreign earnings.

**SANTO DOMINGO**

The capital city of Santo Domingo was founded by Columbus's brother, Bartolomé, in 1496. The city became the main base from which Spain launched its conquest of the region. The city has many recently restored colonial buildings dating back to the 16th century.

	HAITI	DOMINICAN REP.
	12 cars per 1,000 people	66 cars per 1,000 people
	16 telephones per 1,000 people	110 telephones per 1,000 people
	6,288 college students	176,995 college students

THE ECONOMY

People in the Dominican Republic have a better standard of living than those in Haiti, where most cannot even afford health care. The economy is stronger in the Republic because it is boosted by earnings from tourism and mining and by a government that encourages new industries, such as textiles. In recent years vacation resorts have sprung up across the country, creating jobs. Many Haitians come here in search of work.

Find out more

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